12 LESSONS

How a paper became a talk people remembered

What I learned from a best paper award

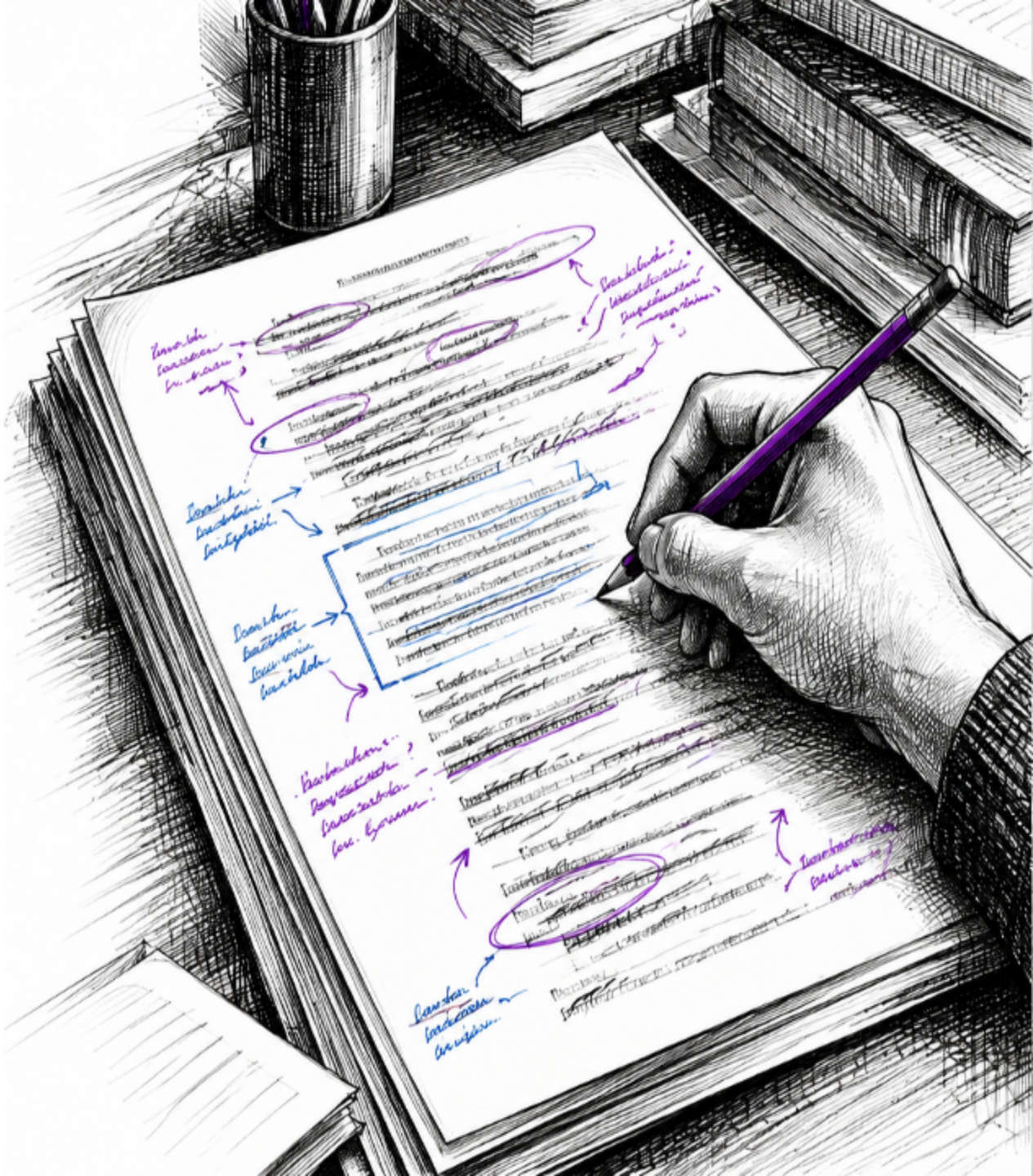
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01

The revision is where clarity happens

After the initial reviews, I treated **every point of confusion as a clue** about the paper's first impression. A promising result can still be difficult to grasp when its motivation, method, or contribution is buried. The most consequential work was revising the paper as a whole, so that readers beyond my closest niche could understand what we had done and why it mattered. The goal was a stronger paper, not merely a point by point response.

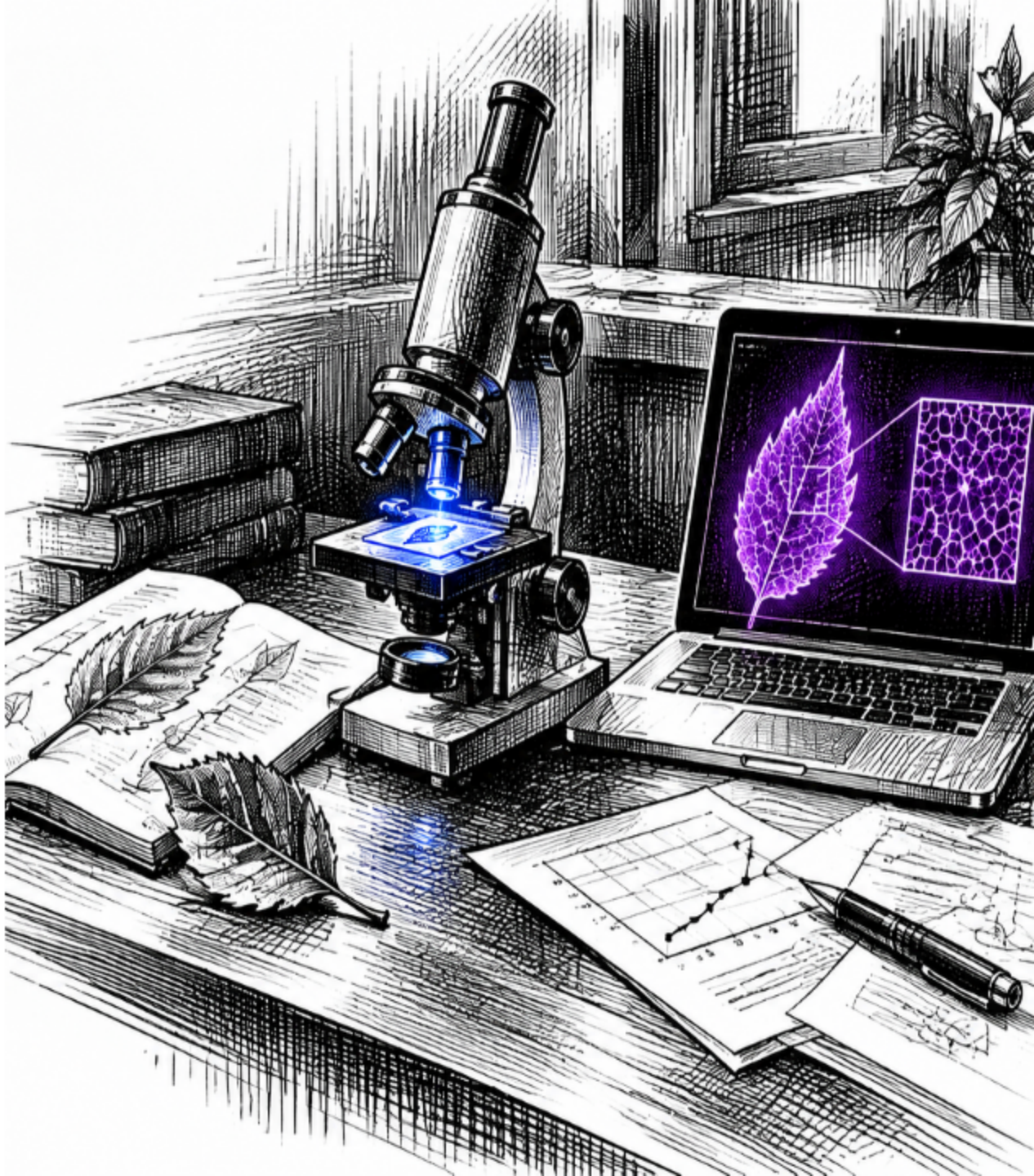


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02

A concrete example can carry the method

Abstract descriptions often make perfect sense to the authors because they already know every step. A reader needs an entry point. I found it useful to choose **one natural example** and follow it through the method, showing what goes in, what changes, and what comes out. A carefully made visualization gives that example a shape. It lets readers verify their understanding before they reach the full evaluation.



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03

Coachability changes the paper

A revised manuscript benefits from another demanding read before the final proceedings version. I asked experienced researchers to challenge the new draft and tried to **hear their reactions as information about the work**, not as judgments about me. That takes practice. Each fresh critique made it easier to see assumptions I had stopped noticing and to respond quickly where the explanation still failed a new reader.



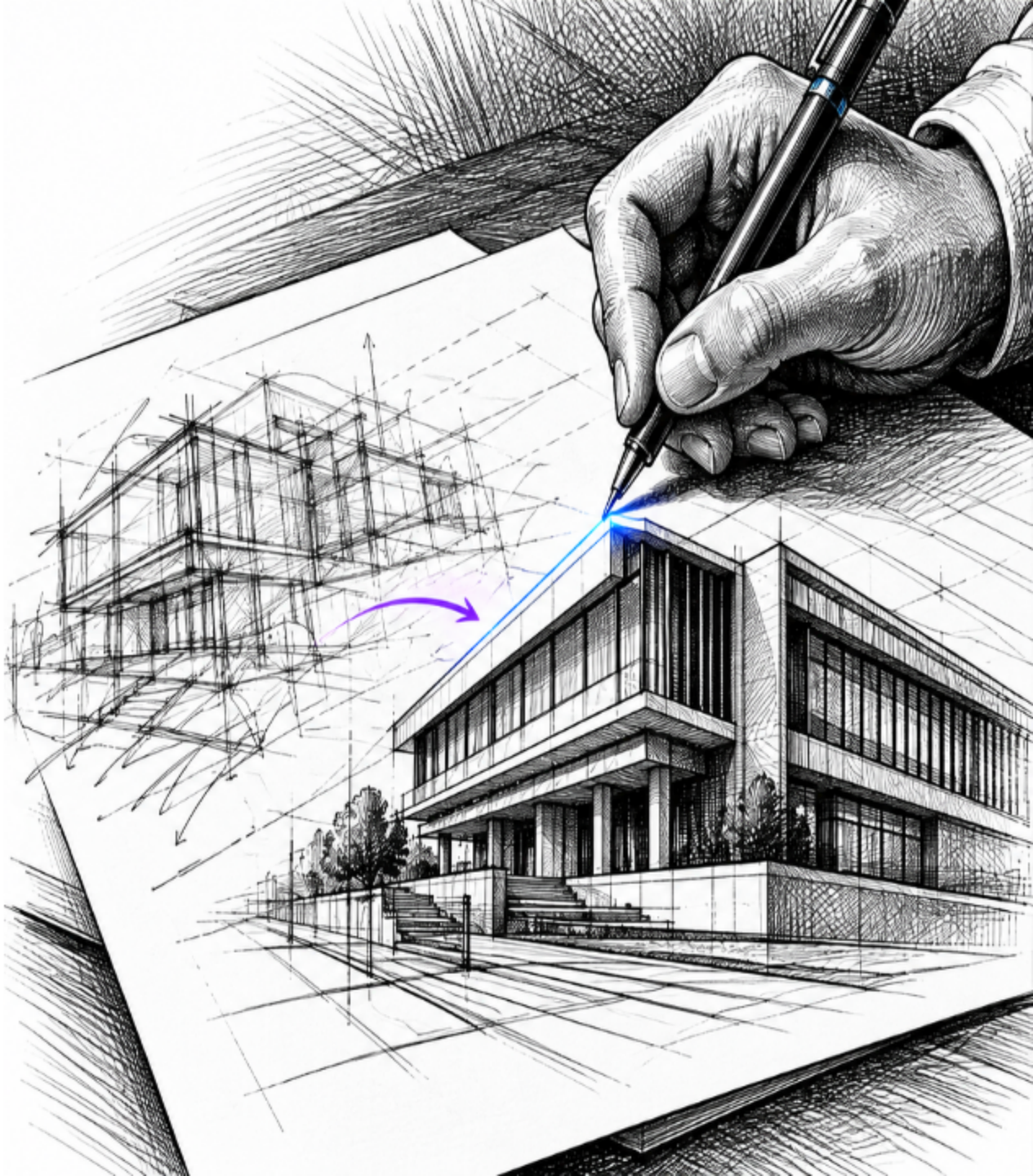
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04

Own every sentence and every figure

AI can help arrange ideas, propose language, and sketch alternatives. It can also leave a paper sounding generic or make its figures look unfinished. I learned to **revisit every assisted sentence and every drawing** with the same care I would give my own first draft. The final visual needs to explain this specific research, and the prose needs to carry the exact claim. The researcher remains responsible for the final choices.

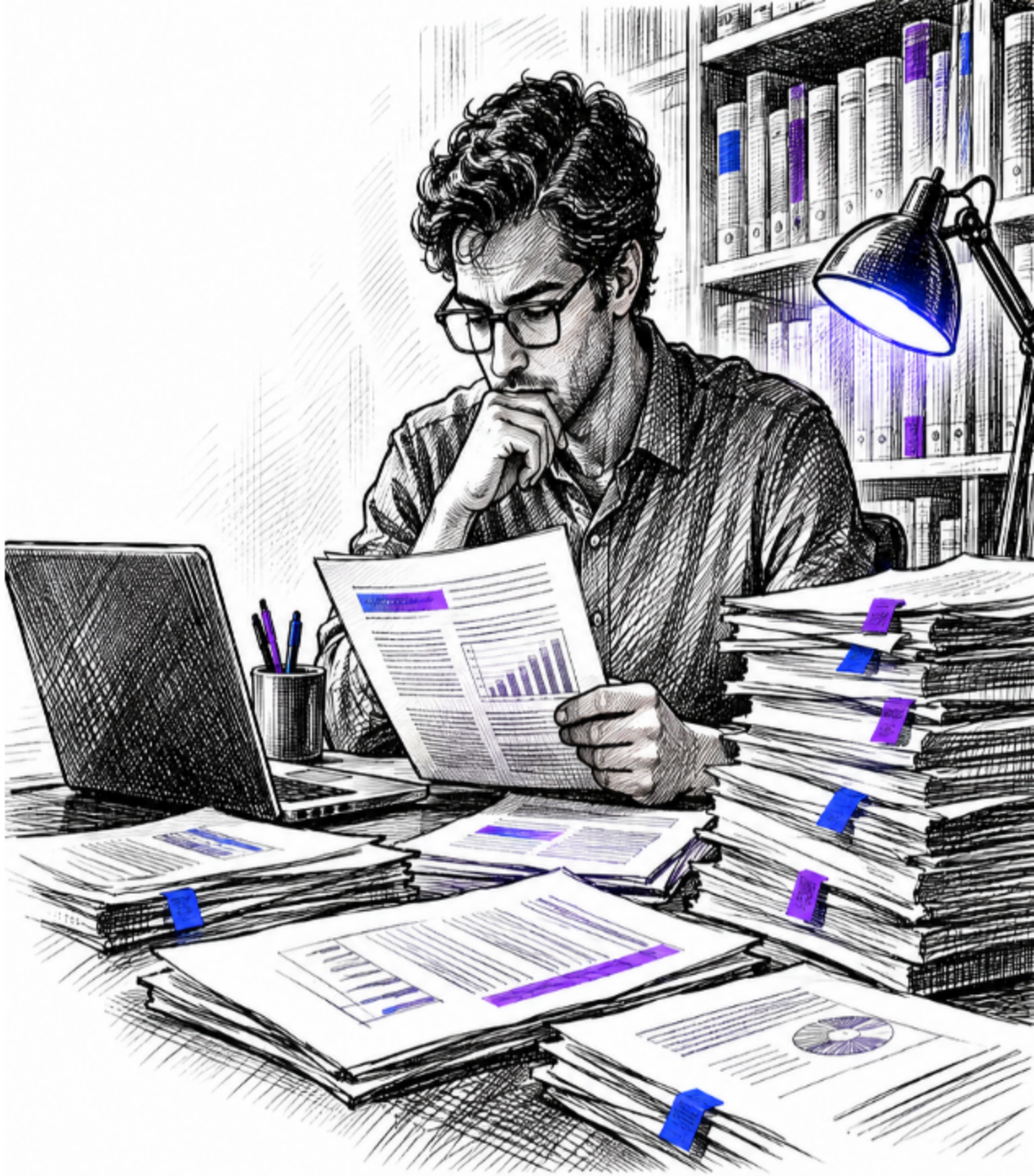
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05

Learn the conference conversation

Before designing the talk, I looked at the conference program and the work the community had chosen to present. That helped me **place my research among adjacent questions** rather than assuming everyone would see its relevance immediately. I then used that understanding to frame the opening: what this audience already cares about, where my work connects, and which new perspective it brings. It also gave me better questions to ask other researchers at the venue.



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06

Interest starts before the session

Conferences are opportunities to learn what others are building and to connect ideas across talks. I tried to **meet people with genuine curiosity**, explain why their work resonated with mine, and invite those who might care to my session. An engaged room can create more substantive questions and stronger conversations afterward. In my experience, visible audience interest was also one element considered when evaluating a presentation. The invitation works best when the connection is real.

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07

Make the unfamiliar feel reachable

For a short research talk, I want the audience to **recognize the starting point before I reveal what is new**. It might be a familiar problem, an established method used in a surprising domain, or a common assumption that the results challenge. This is the “familiar surprise” I aim for. Simple slides support that sequence: the audience should spend its attention on the idea rather than decoding a dense layout.



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08

Study talks as carefully as papers

I learn presentation craft by watching effective research talks and reading speaking guidance, including MIT’s How to Speak. I sometimes work from a video transcript, extract useful principles into a reusable instruction set, and ask an AI agent for a rough first structure. That gives me material to react to. I then **rewrite the narrative and redesign the slides** around my actual argument, timing, and speaking style.



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09

An academic talk can be enjoyable

Rigor does not require a flat delivery. At a long conference, people have already listened to many sessions by the time they reach yours. **A small joke, a familiar observation, or a well placed moment of surprise** can help them reconnect with the argument. I try to keep that lightness relevant to the research and respectful of the room. The purpose is to make a serious idea easier to follow and remember.

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10

Confidence needs a time buffer

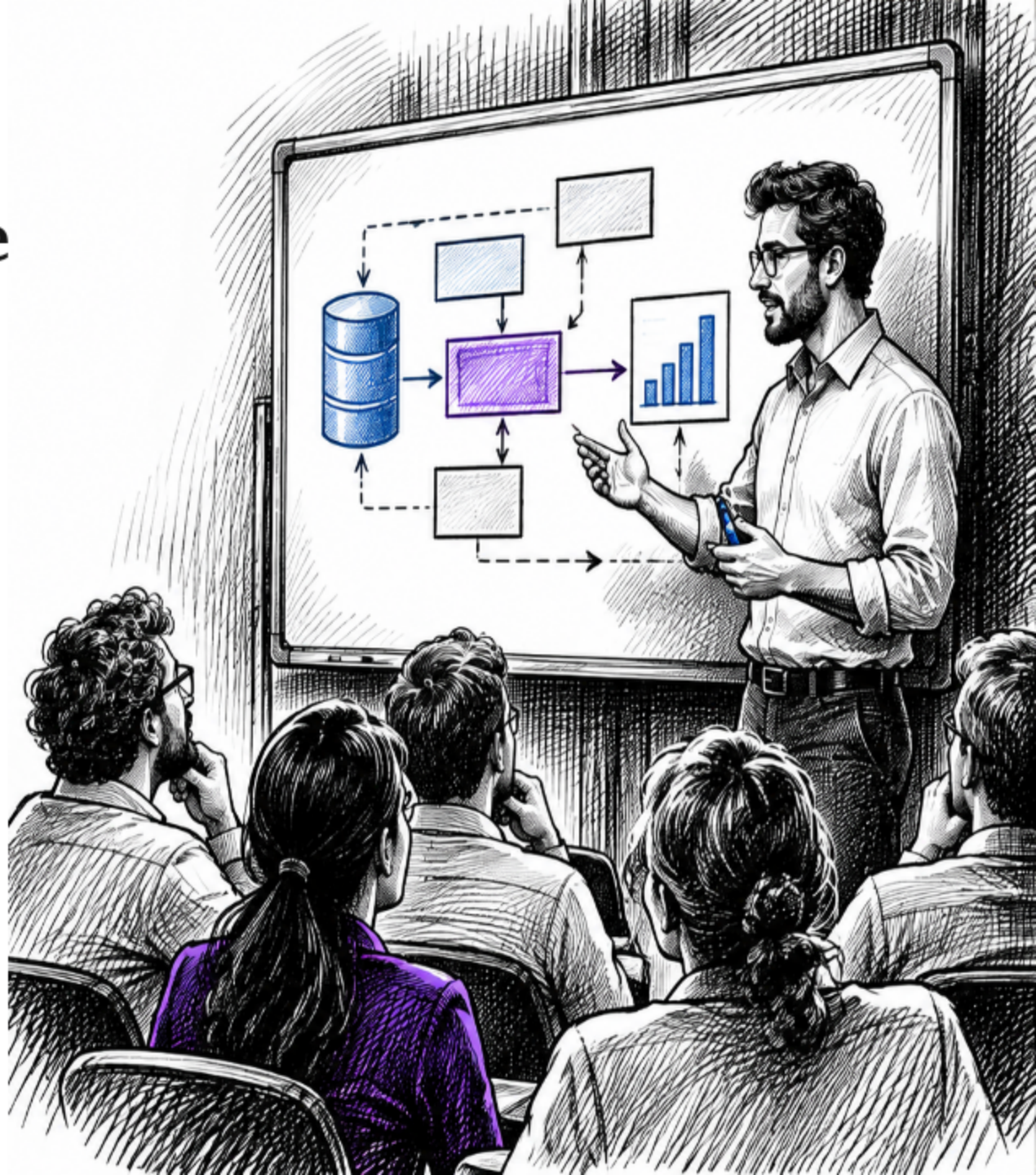
Practicing aloud reveals where an explanation takes longer than it looked on the slide. I plan the core talk to **finish before the formal limit**, leaving space for pauses, transitions, and an unexpected interruption. If a slot offers 15 minutes to present and 5 for questions, roughly 12 to 13 rehearsed minutes can be a useful target. The remaining time is a buffer, while the talk still contains enough substance to do the work justice.



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The questions are part of the talk

The presentation continues when someone asks what the solution already supports, where its limits lie, or how it might develop. I **prepare concrete answers and examples** for those likely questions rather than relying only on rehearsed slides. When the future work is genuinely unresolved, I can still explain a plausible next experiment and the reasoning behind it. That combination of specificity and honest uncertainty communicates command of the research.



12

Be proud and remain curious

Acceptance at a conference is already an achievement, and it is healthy to recognize the effort behind it. At the same time, I want to be someone who **listens to other researchers, welcomes critique**, and treats people respectfully throughout the event. An award is a wonderful moment, but it does not finish the learning. The habits and relationships built around the work will shape what I can do next.

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